Chinese had previously acknowledged that the route and even the Karakoram Pass was part of Indian territory.

Accordingly the Chinese decided to occupy a line that would link three heights (PTs 19080, 18630 and 18475) in the Lungnak Lungspa Valley and the western extremities of Spur II and Range I to the south of the Chip Chap River. To accomplish this task, the Chinese would have to take on eleven Indian pickets, which though lightly held, would not be easy. Three strong positions were held by 18 J&K Militia—Bishan (one platoon), Chandni (two platoons less a section commanded by Lieutenant Chhewang Rigzen with Subedar Sonam Stopdan as his 2IC) and Takkar (two platoons and a section) while the others were even smaller posts. The Chinese commanders came to the conclusion that infantry attacks at heights exceeding 16,000 feet would be useless and they would rather try and blast the Indians out with sustained artillery and mortar fire.

The terrain to the south of the Chip Chap River was markedly different with the two ranges, Spur I and Range I, making troop movement against the Indian posts Takkar and Jodha difficult. However, both these positions were situated at quite a distance from the supply posts at DBO, Pramodak and Chandni, and were thus vulnerable if their supplies could be cut off. The Chinese on the other hand, had a road running from Qizil Jilga right up to the Chip Chap and Lungnak Lungspa River junction. Hence, it made sense for them to launch their main attack on the northern and middle part of the DBO sector.

There were twenty militiamen, mostly non-combatants, at Chandni and Hongshongtou drop zones, when on 19 October 1962 the Chinese opened fire with medium and heavy mortars at 11 p.m. These unarmed men, employed to collect drops and ferry them to nearby posts, were in no position to fight back. Quite a few were killed while the others managed to escape to Chandni. The next morning the DZs were abandoned and ablaze.

The Chinese also targeted the observation posts at Bishan, Pramodak and Jodha, while also firing sporadically at Bijoy, Trikoni, Pakwan and Takkar through the night. Pramodak II (all observation posts are marked as II) was the main target and at dawn, the Chinese, presuming that all the men had been killed in the bombardment, started to close in on the Indian post. Commanded by a naik, the five Indian soldiers fought tenaciously. All of them were eventually killed, but not before they had exacted a heavy toll on the Chinese. The attacking troops were all Sinkiang Muslims and it is